

A Plain-Language Glossary

Words you may hear in the days ahead, explained simply.

Autopsy

A careful medical examination after death, performed by a pathologist, to help understand an illness or the cause of death.

Pathologist

A physician with special training to examine tissues and determine how disease and injury affect the body.

Anatomic pathology

The area of medicine that studies the body and its tissues to diagnose disease — the division that performs autopsies.

Medical examiner

A county official, usually a physician, responsible by law for investigating certain deaths (for example, accidental, sudden, or unexpected).

Cause of death

The disease or injury that led to death (for example, a heart attack).

Manner of death

The broad category of how a death came about — natural, accident, and so on — determined by the medical examiner when they are involved.

Death certificate

The official legal record of a death. Certified copies are usually obtained through the funeral home.

Executor (personal representative)

The person the Probate Court authorizes to manage a deceased person's estate, including requesting medical records.

Letter of authority

The document the Probate Court gives the executor, confirming their authority to act for the estate.

Probate

The legal process of settling a person's estate after they die.

Next of kin

A person's closest living relative(s), who may be asked to make certain decisions.

Hospice

Care focused on comfort and quality of life near the end of life; Henry Ford Hospice also offers grief support to families afterward.

Bereavement

The experience of grief and mourning after someone dies.

Chaplain

A trained provider of spiritual and emotional support for people of any faith, or none.